to me a beautiful and tranquil spot. It was early morning and vivid pink lotus buds were opening on the surface of the water. But the villagers shuddered as they passed it. Many dead bodies had been found floating in the pond after cyclone Nargis and, no matter how many times it was cleaned and washed out with lime powder, people still found that the water had a peculiar taste." (196).

THE PERSPECTIVE OF THE MYANMAR AUTHORITIES

It has been argued that the harsh criticism leveled against the regime is somewhat overstated. The government's actions generated a high level of criticism, as global leaders grew frustrated over the lack of cooperation and regard for human life. The disaster was unprecedented in the history of Myanmar. The authorities in Myanmar felt that the international community quickly politicized the crisis to harm the standing of the regime. In addition, the fact that the military was undergoing a generational change may have also complicated relief efforts. The fact that this transition was taking place may have caused confusion and panic within the new authority structure. Low-level authorities may have been fearful of making any substantive decision.

In addition, Myanmar was coming out of the turmoil of the 2007 Saffron Revolution. The relationship between the regime and the international community became more contentious based on the criticism leveled at the regime following the brutal crackdown against political protesters and monks. The paranoia of the regime was most evident in how they handled the media and information on the crisis. Significant restrictions were placed on the media throughout the ordeal.

The cyclone hitting one week prior to the planned constitutional referendum also created enormous problems. All of the government's attention was focused on this seminal event that was the cornerstone of the transitional plan. The decision of the regime to go forward with the process (even though it was delayed in some areas) was condemned by the entire international community. It showed a callous indifference to the suffering of the people at a critical time in the history of Myanmar. Most believed the referendum was a farce with the outcome never in doubt.